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Among the Shahsevan Nomads

A film by Adel Mohabatian

ETHNOGRAPHIC DOCUMENTARY

RUNTIME 72 MIN 44 SEC

October 2026

FILM / RESEARCH / VISUAL ETHNOGRAPHY



Synopsis

On the slopes of Mount Sabalan and across the plains of Moghan, life follows the movement of flocks and the turning of seasons. Behind the beauty of the landscape lies a world of labour, uncertainty, and changing relationships of power.

"Among the Shahsevan Nomads" follows shepherds and pastoral families beyond romantic images of migration. Seven allegorical interludes bring a shepherd into dialogue with sheep, his wife, a flock dog, a government employee, an employer, livestock traders, and finally himself. The encounters converge on one question: Who cares for the person who has spent a lifetime caring for others?

My name is **Adel Mohabatian**, and I am a PhD candidate in Economic Sociology and Development at the University of Tabriz. For many years, I have been drawn to ethnographic research and fieldwork alongside different groups of people—a practice that has allowed me to understand their lives from within. This interest took me, during my doctoral studies, on a research journey unlike any I had experienced before: an ethnographic inquiry among one of Iran's most concentrated and vulnerable nomadic populations, the Shahsavan of the northwest, around Meshgin Shahr.

From December 2024 to September 2025, I lived among them in their obas (encampments), slept beside them, and followed their migration routes. I shared meals with them, rose with their flocks before sunrise, and listened to the voices of their elders and children. Gradually, as **Zivar**, the mother of the family, put it, I became like one of her sons. The most valuable outcome of this experience was that, for a time at least, I became part of their world. The central research question that emerged from the field was **an ethnographic study of the processes of impoverishment among the Shahsavan nomads**.

Yet something on this journey shook me. I realized that written words—even the most meticulous research articles and books—were not enough. They cannot hold the wind that blows against the walls of a Shahsavan alachiq, convey the raw force of a shepherd's cry across the hills, or reveal the quiet pride of women who, burdened by family responsibilities and poverty, may work even harder than the men.

So, with limited personal equipment, I began filming. I wanted my fieldwork to become not only an academic dissertation but also the beginning of a documentary: a film that could carry the Shahsavan story beyond the confines of academia into a wider world, where it might touch hearts, raise these issues in the public sphere, and help create the conditions for change.




Beyond One
Family:
The Larger Picture

Beyond the micro-level of family relations and hierarchies, there are broader structural issues shaping the lives of the Shahsevan nomads. These include:

the bureaucratic system of nomadic affairs;
the powerful mafias surrounding quota allocations;
the dominance of large-scale sheep brokers;
reverse migration of nomads from cities back to the steppe;
the imbalance between the price of barley and the price of sheep meat;
the question of shepherds insurance;
access to water and pasture;
the state of nomadic roads and migration routes;
communication and mobile phone coverage; health services;
veterinary medicine and access to livestock specialists;
the situation of young brides and the new generation of nomads;
changing gender dynamics in nomadic labor and its increasing masculinization;
the feminization of nomadic poverty;
and many other critical issues.



Through interviews and field observations in both winter and summer pastures, these factors come together to form the puzzle of the processes of impoverishment and the decline of the Shahsevan tribe.

The film and its seven interludes

An observational world interrupted by allegorical conversations



A question at the centre

Who cares for the person who has spent a lifetime caring for others?

The film moves between everyday observation and seven allegorical encounters. The shepherd addresses sheep, his wife, a flock dog, a government employee, an employer, livestock traders, and finally himself.

I didn't begin filmmaking with this dissertation. Some years back, I was privileged to study under the late **Abbas Kiarostami**, a master Iranian filmmaker. I spent three straight years (2011-2013) learning from him to observe the world cinematically, to observe beauty in things as ordinary as they can be, and to let reality speak on its own and not impose anything on it. Since 2008, I've directed a few short movies and done documentaries but never attempted to release them on a wide screen for personal reasons. Filmmaking was just for me a way of learning more about life, rather than making a career.

And I do know something now: art and research are lacking without one another. Ethnography alone on the shelf is incomplete. Film alone, shallow. Together they can provide a portal wherein lived experience is not only comprehended but also lived.

This is the very reason that I am committed not only to writing my dissertation, but to making this ethnographic documentary film. It will not be a voyeur's account of the Shahsevan, but one that emerges from years of engagement and presence, and with closeness and trust.



Research as a way of seeing

Shahsavan pastoral communities around Meshgin Shahr

The documentary grew from extended ethnographic presence: living alongside pastoral families, accompanying flocks and listening to accounts of work, care, migration and changing livelihoods.

The field research considers everyday relations with markets, land, animals and institutions. It approaches shepherding as embodied knowledge and labour rather than as a picturesque remnant of the past.

The camera extends this inquiry into public conversation. It does not replace the interviews, fieldnotes or analysis on which the research is grounded.





A Family, A Tribe, A Vanishing Way of Life.

As I went about my fieldwork, I stayed with a Shahsevan family whose existence perfectly encapsulated the hopes and struggles of the greater tribe. Their tent was home and metaphor: susceptible to the winds of change but firmly grounded in tradition and hardiness.

Images from the field

Selected field photographs · publication permissions to be confirmed











Film information

Verified details only

Official title	Among the Shahsevan Nomads
Persian title	Dar Miyan-e Ashayer-e Il-e Shahsavan (در میان عشایر ایل شاهسون)
Format	**HD / 16:9 /** Feature-length ethnographic documentary
Runtime	72 min 44 sec
Editing completed	October 2026
Director / producer	Adel Mohabatian
Research / camera / sound / edit	Adel Mohabatian
Research advisers	Asghar Izadi Jeyran; Nematollah Taghavi

Principal credits



Adel Mohabatian

Director · Researcher · Cinematographer · Sound Recordist · Editor · Producer

Key Guide

Ali Moharami

Research advisers

Asghar Izadi Jeyran

Nematollah Taghavi

A film made through relationships

Community participation and institutional cooperation



The closing credits acknowledge approximately one hundred Shahsavan nomads participants.

Also thanks to individual collaborators, local communities, nomadic-affairs administrations, cultural-heritage representatives and the University of Tabriz.

Press & screening inquiries

Official resources and contact

Among the Shahsevan Nomads

A film by Adel Mohabatian

72 min 44 sec



Press / screenings

adel.mohabatian2007@gmail.com

Film website

adelmohabatian.github.io/films/shahsavan/

Trailer

youtu.be/ZYH5EeoFrqw

Instagram: @Shahsavan.Documentary